

‘B\$#@c**d,’ I said by way of greeting, ‘. . . isn’t it enough that you cheated me once? Or is there something more you want to rob me of?’ I had got over my rage, but was not going to forgive him so quickly.

‘Your anger is perfectly justified. Abuse me some more if it helps you get over it. But after that let’s talk like grownups,’ Lucky said.

The following evening I drove down to Lucky’s place at Khar. He greeted me warmly, and then asked with mock fear: ‘I hope you don’t have a gun or knife on you.’

‘That would be being kind to you. I was thinking of something more painful,’ I replied.

He told me that he had arranged a meeting for me with his influential mentor that evening. Before heading for the meeting, Lucky apologized for what he had done.

‘Look Lala, don’t take this personally. I can assure you one thing – your loss will be more than made up,’ he said.

‘Let’s see,’ I said, somewhat sceptically.

We met up with Lucky’s godfather at his office on Hill Road in Bandra. He appeared to be in his mid-forties, a tall man who bore a passing resemblance to the yesteryear Bollywood star Navin Nischal. He had that same tranquil and dreamy look about him. His hair was dyed black, and he wore it slightly long. He was good-looking though his once sharp features were slowly running to fat, and I suspected it had to do with a fondness for booze. I mentally nicknamed him Monk.

‘My pleasure to have you here, Lala,’ he said, with a warm smile and a firm handshake. ‘I have heard of you from some good people, and had been wanting to meet you for a while now. Better late than never.’

Monk spoke fluent English, and certainly did not sound like a seasoned stockbroker. An investment banker, perhaps.

Having introduced us, Lucky left, saying he had some other work to attend to. I knew this was pre-planned.

Monk and I discussed the markets. He wanted to know my view. I said I was bearish for the moment.

‘So is everybody on the street,’ Monk said. ‘I think we may have hit the bottom for the time being. Still, Asia will take a while to settle. I don’t see a bull market any time soon.’

Monk’s interests went beyond markets. He followed politics closely, collected antique stuff and called himself a ‘serious amateur’ photographer.